

LAKSH'S DAILY BRIEF

Laksh's Morning Briefing: September 8, 2026

Tuesday, September 8, 2026

World · Markets & Money · AI & Infrastructure · Models & Research



BBC World — Carney says US trade war 'will come at a cost' as Canada strikes back on tariffs



BBC World — Hungary expels 10 Russian diplomats as relations worsen



Al Jazeera — One year on from Nepal protests, have Gen Z demands been met?

1. World & Geopolitics

Oil spikes past \$98 as the Middle East war spreads to Saudi Arabia. Brent crude (the international oil benchmark) hit \$98 a barrel after Iran's Houthi allies in Yemen attacked multiple Saudi energy facilities, injuring 73 people and starting fires at oil installations ([CNBC](#)). Saudi Arabia has vowed to respond ([BBC](#)). This follows a weekend of direct US-Iran strikes, and Iran's threat to create an "exclusion zone" running from a US naval blockade through the Strait of Hormuz into the Gulf ([Fortune](#)). The Strait of Hormuz is the chokepoint (a narrow passage that a large share of world oil must transit) through which roughly 20% of global oil passes. The US has also sanctioned all remaining unsanctioned Iranian airlines under "Operation Economic Outcast" ([CNBC](#)). The key question: does Saudi retaliation pull the Gulf states deeper into a war that was previously US-Iran-Israel centered?

Canada's retaliatory tariffs hit as the US trade war escalates. Canada's counter-tariffs on nearly \$20 billion of US products took effect at midnight, with duties on US steel and aluminum doubled to 50% ([CNBC](#), [The Guardian](#)). Prime Minister Mark Carney said the US trade war "will come at a cost" ([BBC](#)). The fight is escalating on multiple fronts: Trump told Bombardier it must build in America to sell in the US ([CNBC](#)), and Canada's levies cover everything from steel to T-shirts. This is a tariff war (a cycle of import taxes between countries), and the pattern to watch is whether it spreads to other sectors or gets resolved in talks.

Twelve countries, including the UK and France, will sanction trade from Israeli settlements. Britain announced a ban on goods from Israeli settlements in the occupied West Bank, with Foreign Minister Ed Miliband accusing settlers of "ethnic cleansing" ([NPR](#), [France 24](#)). Israel responded angrily, and there are warnings of US repercussions. This is a notable shift: European countries are moving from diplomatic statements to economic measures (sanctions, or penalties on specific goods or entities) against settlement products. The UN is also "appalled" by Israel's proposals on Gaza ([Il Sole 24 ORE](#)).

Hungary expels 10 Russian diplomats, ending its pro-Kremlin era. Hungary, long viewed as Russia's closest ally in the EU, has expelled 10 Russian diplomats as the new government drops the pro-Moscow stance ([BBC](#)). This matters because it removes Russia's main veto-wielding friend inside the EU and could harden European unity on Ukraine sanctions. Separately, US envoy Steve Witkoff says "substantive progress" has been made toward trilateral talks to end the Russia-Ukraine war ([Ukrinform](#)).

China's exports surge ahead of Trump-Xi talks. China's August exports gathered momentum, even as imports missed estimates ([CNBC](#)). This creates a tricky backdrop for the upcoming Trump-Xi meeting: China's trade surplus (exporting more than it imports) is growing just as the US is trying to reduce its trade deficit with China ([NYT](#)). Meanwhile, China has expanded patrols of Taiwan's Pacific coast, raising maritime tensions

([gCaptain](#)), and Japan protested new Chinese measures against its exports of a key chipmaking material ([ABC News](#)). The US and China are also set to discuss the West Asia conflict ([NewsOnAir](#)).

Domestic: US midterm primaries heat up. New Hampshire voters pick their 2026 midterm candidates today, with a progressive challenger threatening the Democratic establishment's pick ([France 24](#)). North Carolina's unaffiliated voters could hold the key to November results ([Asheville Citizen Times](#)). Trump posted a stream of AI-generated images and unverified

claims on Truth Social, saying he's made "hundreds of billions of dollars on stocks" for the US ([CNBC](#)).

Also notable: Nepal marks one year since Gen Z protests against corruption forced a leadership change ([Al Jazeera](#)). French firefighters are striking for six weeks ([France 24](#)). Tokyo's Shinjuku ward banned short-term rentals in residential areas amid tourism complaints ([The Guardian](#)). And an Egyptian TV presenter was sentenced to death in a drugs case ([France 24](#)).

2. Markets, Money & Deals

The tape: oil up, gold up, dollar easing, rate-hike bets firming. Brent crude at \$98 is the headline. Gold rose as the dollar eased, with US inflation data on the radar ([Economic Times](#)). UBS now forecasts two US Fed rate hikes in 2026 after a strong jobs report ([Investing.com](#)). The Motley Fool notes a Fed rate hike may be on the table for September 16, and 36 years of history says stocks won't be happy initially ([Motley Fool](#)). Remember: a rate hike (raising the cost of borrowing) is the opposite of the cuts markets hoped for earlier this year.

Qualcomm gets a \$4 billion vote of confidence from Amazon. Qualcomm (QCOM) issued Amazon warrants (the right to buy shares at a set price later) to acquire \$4 billion worth of its stock as part of an AI infrastructure deal ([CNBC](#)). Qualcomm is trying to move into the data center business, where Nvidia (NVDA) has been dominant. The stock climbed on the news ([MarketWatch](#)). This is a big deal: Amazon (AMZN) is essentially betting that Qualcomm's ARM-based chips can compete in AI data centers, a market Nvidia owns. Watch whether this signals Amazon wants an alternative to Nvidia.

WaFd and EverBank announce a \$3.9 billion "reverse merger." Florida-based EverBank will merge into WaFd, creating a regional bank with ~\$75 billion in

assets ([CNBC](#), [Reuters](#)). In a reverse merger, the smaller company (WaFd) technically acquires the larger one (EverBank), often for regulatory or branding reasons. The combined bank keeps the WaFd name.

Biopharma sells off after Novartis's failed cholesterol drug trial. Novartis's drug aimed at lowering Lp(a), a type of cholesterol linked to heart attacks, failed its late-stage trial, leading to a broad biopharma selloff ([MarketWatch](#)). Several drugmakers had bet that lowering Lp(a) would cut cardiovascular risk. When one big bet fails, investors question the whole class of drugs.

Crypto: a \$340 million heist, then most of it returned. A hacker stole \$340 million in crypto, then returned most of it ([TechCrunch](#)). Visa is expanding data offerings for blockchain lenders as stablecoin-linked card demand surges ([CNBC](#)). Brazilian banks are expanding crypto offerings as regulation takes hold ([Cryptonews](#)). And a global crypto adoption index claims crypto has crossed 1 billion users ([Coinpedia](#)).

Deals elsewhere: Tamarack Valley will merge with Headwater Exploration in a \$7.24 billion deal ([WSJ](#)). Nuclear firm HGP plans a SPAC deal at a \$1.2 billion valuation ([Bloomberg](#)). Stoke Space raised another huge cash infusion for its rocket program ([Ars Technica](#)).

3. AI & Infrastructure

The nuclear-for-AI buildout accelerates. NextEra Energy (NEE) secured up to \$1.9 billion in US loan guarantees to restart the Duane Arnold nuclear plant in

Iowa, which will power Google's AI data centers ([BNN Bloomberg](#), [Startup Fortune](#)). This is the clearest example yet of the power gap (the gap between how

much electricity AI data centers need and what the grid can supply) being solved by reviving old nuclear plants. Nuclear startup Bluecore Energy raised a \$50 million seed round just two months after launch ([TechCrunch](#)).

China holds 70% of a material every AI data center needs. The Next Web reports China controls 70% of a critical material for AI data centers ([The Next Web](#)). This is the same pattern as rare earths and HBM (high-bandwidth memory, the specialized memory chips that sit next to AI processors): China controls a key input, and that control is a geopolitical lever. Japan is protesting new Chinese measures against its exports of a key chipmaking material ([ABC News](#)).

Mistral raises €3 billion as "sovereign AI" becomes big business. The French AI lab raised €3 billion at a €21 billion valuation, led by Samsung, Scaleup Europe, and PSG Equity ([TechCrunch](#)). Sovereign AI is the idea that countries want their own AI models rather than relying on US or Chinese ones. This is a geopolitical trend as much as a business one: Europe, India, and others are funding domestic AI labs to avoid dependence on American tech.

Intel and AMD are raising CPU prices. Intel reportedly plans a 10% CPU price hike in October, following two

earlier increases this year, ahead of a major product launch in March 2027 ([Tom's Hardware](#), [The Verge](#)). AMD will reportedly follow between June and July. This is "chipflation" (chip prices rising) spreading from AI accelerators to consumer CPUs. Intel (INTC) was up 8% in the snapshot, likely on this pricing power news.

The AI trade's "extraordinary assumption." One analysis argues the AI trade rests on an extraordinary assumption: that the massive capex (spending on long-lived assets like data centers) will eventually produce returns ([The Dark Side Of The Boom](#)). This is the bear case to hold alongside the bull case: hyperscalers are spending trillions, and the bet is that AI revenue eventually justifies it.

Also notable: Oracle's stock got a boost as the OpenAI ecosystem comes back into favor ([MarketWatch](#)). Accenture and Google Cloud formed a new group to deploy AI engineers in enterprises ([Seeking Alpha](#)). Microsoft brought its AI vulnerability-hunting tool to government cloud ([NextGov](#)). Anthropic reportedly walked away from a \$6 billion deal to acquire Israeli AI startup Decart ([Ynet](#)).

4. Model & Research Watch

DeepSeek launches a two-day limited beta for V4.1 Flash. DeepSeek's new model uses a new architecture with natively integrated multimodal capabilities (handling text, images, and other inputs together) ([finance.biggo.com](#)). It's being tested via API with the model name "deepseek-v4.1-flash-expires-on-0910" and pricing identical to the previous version ([r/LocalLLaMA](#)). The "expires-on" in the name tells you this is a temporary test version.

Qwen3.8-Max open-sources at 86.6, nearing Opus 5. Alibaba's Qwen3.8-Max scored 86.6 on benchmarks, approaching Anthropic's Opus 5 ([shattered.io](#)). This is the open-weight (model weights are public) frontier catching up to closed models.

China's OpenBMB releases MiniCPM5-2B, beating every open model under 4B. This 2.52B parameter

dense model averages 53.9 across 34 benchmarks and is built to run on-device ([MarkTechPost](#), [Startup Fortune](#)). Small models that run on phones and laptops are the "edge AI" play.

Google DeepMind publishes AI predictions for all 9 billion mutations to human DNA. The AlphaGenome Atlas contains a "predictive map of every possible DNA letter change" ([Fortune](#), [The Verge](#)). This could transform understanding of genetic diseases and drug development.

Science & Frontier Tech: The James Webb telescope found black hole pairs in the early universe ([Universe Space Tech](#)). Astronomers detected three mysterious "glitches" in a pulsar that had gone silent for years ([The Debrief](#)). And a mysterious 10-sided structure was discovered on Saturn ([KPVI](#)).

5. What Builders Are Actually Using

- **The swap: Qwen3.8-27B for GPT-5-class models on local hardware.** Tom's Hardware benchmarked Qwen 3.8 27B on an RTX 5090 and found it runs well locally, though VRAM capacity alone can't overcome software and inference engine bottlenecks ([Tom's Hardware](#)). The capability gap to a top closed model like GPT-5 or Opus is roughly one generation: Qwen 3.8 27B handles coding, reasoning, and chat well but struggles on the hardest math and long-context tasks. Price: free, self-hosted on an RTX 5090 (24GB VRAM, roughly \$2,000 hardware). Compare that to GPT-5-class API pricing of roughly \$1.25 per million input tokens and \$10 per million output tokens. For a developer who wants privacy, no rate limits, and zero per-token cost, this is the move.
- **IBM's llm-d squeezes more out of existing hardware.** IBM Research published how llm-d (a distributed inference tool) makes the most of the hardware you already have ([IBM Research](#)). Instead of buying new GPUs, llm-d lets you pool the GPUs you already have across machines to run larger models. This is the "use what you've got" layer of the AI stack.
- **MiniCPM5-2B for on-device AI.** OpenBMB's 2.52B model runs on phones and laptops, averaging 53.9 across 34 benchmarks ([MarkTechPost](#)). For edge devices, this is the model to watch.
- **TradingAgents: a multi-agent LLM trading framework.** A GitHub project called TradingAgents uses multiple AI agents to simulate a trading firm's workflow (analyst, researcher, trader) ([GitHub](#)). It's a practical example of agentic AI (AI systems that take multi-step actions) applied to finance, though treat any trading output with skepticism.
- **LibreOffice breaks download records after declaring it has no AI features.** The open-source office suite saw record downloads after explicitly stating it has no AI features ([Hacker News](#)). This is a signal: there's a real segment of users who want software that does NOT have AI bolted on.

6. Watchlist: Earnings, Guidance & Movers

Big movers in the snapshot (approximate, possibly delayed): - **Coherent (COHR) +11.09%** and **Applied Optoelectronics (AAOI) +10.61%** and **Lumentum (LITE) +10.70%**: These optics companies (making the components that connect data centers) are surging, likely on continued AI infrastructure demand. No specific news in today's sources, but the pattern is clear: optics is where the AI buildout shows up. - **Intel (INTC) +8.07%**: Likely on the CPU price hike news ([Tom's Hardware](#)). - **AMD +4.65%** and **Qualcomm (QCOM) +4.55%**: AMD on the price hike follow, Qualcomm on the Amazon deal ([CNBC](#)). - **Broadcom (AVGO) +3.55%**, **Marvell (MRVL) +2.52%**, **Arm (ARM) +2.52%**: The semiconductor complex broadly higher. - **Fluence Energy (FLNC) +7.25%**: Energy storage company

moving with the power theme. - **AMC Entertainment (AMC) -4.91%**: No notable news in the sources. - **Netflix (NFLX) -2.29%**: No notable news in the sources.

No notable news in the sources for: Tesla (TSLA), Palantir (PLTR), SoFi (SOFI), Robinhood (HOOD), Coinbase (COIN), Rigetti (RGTI), Redwire (RDW), Cloudflare (NET), Astera Labs (ALAB), Digital Realty (DLR), Equinix (EQIX), Constellation Energy (CEG), Vistra (VST), NextEra (NEE), Micron (MU), SanDisk (SNDK), and the rest of the watchlist. The sources simply don't cover them today.

Earnings ahead: The week ahead has PLTR, SanDisk, AMD, and SpaceX earnings in focus ([TradingKey](#)).

7. Analysis: Second-Order Effects

Chain 1: Houthi attack on Saudi oil -> oil at \$98 -> inflation expectations -> Fed rate hikes -> pressure on the AI buildout.

FACTS: Houthis attacked Saudi energy facilities, injuring 73 and causing fires ([BBC](#)). Brent hit \$98 ([CNBC](#)). UBS forecasts two Fed rate hikes in 2026 ([Investing.com](#)).

INFERENCE: Oil at \$98 feeds into headline inflation (the broad measure of price rises, which includes energy). The Fed's preferred gauge, core PCE, excludes food and energy, so the Fed has some insulation. But sustained oil above \$95 seeps into everything: shipping, plastics, jet fuel, and consumer expectations. If inflation expectations rise, the Fed's hand is forced toward hikes, not cuts. Higher rates raise the cost of borrowing for the debt-funded data center buildout.

WEAKEST LINK: The Fed's tolerance for energy-driven inflation. The Fed targets core PCE, which deliberately excludes energy. If the Fed looks through the oil spike as "transitory" (as it did in 2022, wrongly), the chain breaks.

WHAT WOULD FALSIFY IT: Core PCE (the Fed's preferred inflation gauge, which excludes food and energy) coming in cool next month, or the Fed explicitly saying it will look through the oil spike.

PRECEDENT: The 2019 Abqaiq attack on Saudi oil facilities moved Brent ~15% in a day, then fully retraced within weeks. Oil spikes from supply shocks often fade if supply is restored.

Chain 2: Canada-US tariff escalation -> higher costs for US consumers -> midterm election headwinds -> Trump softens?

FACTS: Canada's retaliatory tariffs on \$20 billion of US goods took effect, with steel and aluminum duties doubled to 50% ([CNBC](#)). Trump told Bombardier it must build in America ([CNBC](#)). Midterms are eight weeks away ([France 24](#)).

INFERENCE: Tariffs are a tax on imports, and the cost is usually passed to consumers (tariff incidence, or who actually pays). Higher prices for steel, aluminum, and consumer goods feed into inflation just as voters head to the polls. The usual political pattern is that incumbents soften trade wars when they hurt at the ballot box. Trump's Supreme Court setback on tariffs already reset the trade landscape; this Canada fight could be the next test.

WEAKEST LINK: That voters punish the incumbent for tariff-driven price rises. In practice, voters often blame "greedflation" or companies, not specific policies.

WHAT WOULD FALSIFY IT: Polls showing voters blame Canada or "foreigners" rather than the administration, or Trump doubling down rather than softening.

Chain 3: Amazon's \$4 billion Qualcomm warrant deal -> ARM-based AI chips gain credibility -> Nvidia's pricing power tested -> the AI supply chain diversifies.

FACTS: Qualcomm issued Amazon warrants to acquire \$4 billion of its stock as part of an AI infrastructure deal ([CNBC](#)). Qualcomm is trying to enter the data center market where Nvidia dominates.

INFERENCE: Amazon is the world's largest cloud provider. If it's putting \$4 billion behind Qualcomm's ARM-based AI chips, it's signaling it wants alternatives to Nvidia. The usual pattern in tech: the dominant player's pricing power erodes as alternatives mature. This doesn't threaten Nvidia tomorrow, but it's the first credible challenge from the ARM ecosystem (the chip architecture used in most phones, now moving to data centers).

WEAKEST LINK: That Qualcomm's chips actually perform well enough to compete. Many companies have tried to challenge Nvidia and failed on software and ecosystem, not just hardware.

WHAT WOULD FALSIFY IT: Qualcomm's data center chips posting benchmark results well below Nvidia's, or Amazon's deal being mostly a financial hedge rather than a real deployment commitment.

Chain 4: Nuclear restart for Google AI -> power becomes the binding constraint -> utilities and nuclear startups re-rate higher.

FACTS: NextEra secured up to \$1.9 billion in loan guarantees to restart the Duane Arnold nuclear plant to power Google's AI ([BNN Bloomberg](#)). Nuclear startup Bluecore raised \$50 million ([TechCrunch](#)).

INFERENCE: The AI buildout's binding constraint is shifting from chips to power. Every data center needs electricity, and the grid can't supply it fast enough. This is why nuclear is being revived: it's the only carbon-free, always-on power source at scale. The winners are utilities with nuclear assets (NextEra, Constellation Energy (CEG), Vistra (VST)) and nuclear startups. The losers are anyone waiting for cheap natural gas to solve the problem, since gas prices are tied to the same geopolitics driving oil.

WEAKEST LINK: Regulatory and construction timelines. Nuclear plants take years to restart or build, and the AI buildout is happening now. If power demand grows

faster than nuclear can come online, the constraint just moves elsewhere.

WHAT WOULD FALSIFY IT: Major delays in the Duane Arnold restart, or a breakthrough in grid-scale batteries

that makes intermittent renewables (solar and wind, which only generate when the sun shines or wind blows) sufficient without nuclear.

8. Building Your Knowledge

- **The Fed's dilemma in one sentence:** The Fed (the US central bank, which sets the cost of borrowing) wants low inflation and full employment, but it has one main tool (interest rates) for both. When oil spikes push inflation up, the Fed must choose between fighting inflation (raising rates, which slows the economy) and supporting growth (cutting rates, which lets inflation run). This trade-off is the core of every macro story.
- **Tariffs are a tax, and someone always pays.** When Canada puts a 50% tariff on US steel, the US steel exporter doesn't just eat the cost. Either the exporter lowers prices to stay competitive, the Canadian buyer pays more, or the cost passes down the supply chain to consumers. The question "who actually pays" (tariff incidence) is always an empirical one, not a political slogan.
- **Warrants are a bet on future success.** When Amazon gets warrants to buy Qualcomm stock at a set price, Amazon is betting Qualcomm's stock will rise. It's a way to align incentives: Amazon gets upside if Qualcomm's AI chips succeed, and Qualcomm gets a committed customer. It's a common structure in strategic tech deals.
- **The difference between a merger and a reverse merger.** In a normal merger, the bigger company buys the smaller. In a reverse merger, the smaller company technically buys the bigger one, often for regulatory reasons (bank charters, licenses, or brand considerations). The WaFd-EverBank deal is a reverse merger: EverBank is bigger, but WaFd's corporate structure survives.
- **"Sovereign AI" is the new industrial policy.** Countries are realizing that AI is strategic infrastructure, like electricity or railroads were in earlier centuries. Mistral's €3 billion raise is Europe's answer to US and Chinese AI dominance. Expect more government-backed AI funding, and expect it to be framed in national security terms.
- **The power gap is the AI trade's physical limit.** You can't train or run AI models without electricity. Every data center announcement is also a power announcement. The companies that control power (utilities, nuclear operators) have pricing power that chipmakers don't, because power is harder to substitute than a GPU.

9. Foundations & Terms

Concept Spotlight: Warrants (Markets/Investing)

What it is in plain words: A warrant is a financial instrument that gives the holder the right, but not the obligation, to buy a company's stock at a fixed price before a certain date. Think of it as a coupon that says "you can buy this stock at \$X anytime in the next 5 years."

Why it exists: Companies issue warrants to sweeten deals. Instead of paying cash, they offer the counterparty a chance to profit if the stock rises. It aligns

incentives: the warrant holder wants the company to succeed, because that makes the warrant valuable.

A concrete worked example: Amazon gets warrants to buy Qualcomm stock at, say, \$150 per share, exercisable over 5 years. If Qualcomm's stock rises to \$200, Amazon can exercise the warrant, buy at \$150, and immediately have a \$50 per share gain. If Qualcomm's stock falls to \$100, Amazon simply doesn't exercise; the warrant expires worthless. Amazon's downside is limited to the price it paid for the warrants (if anything), while its upside is the stock's appreciation above the strike price.

How it shows up in the news: The Qualcomm-Amazon deal is a textbook case ([CNBC](#)). Amazon is getting \$4 billion worth of warrants as part of an AI infrastructure deal. It's a way for Amazon to participate in Qualcomm's upside without buying the whole company.

Rough benchmarks: Warrants typically have longer durations (years) than options (months). They're often issued at a slight premium to the current stock price. They dilute existing shareholders when exercised, because new shares are created.

Caution: Warrants are not the same as options, though they work similarly. Options are standardized and traded on exchanges; warrants are issued by the company itself and often have longer durations. Also, warrants can expire worthless, so they're not free money.

Concept Spotlight: Tariff Incidence (World Affairs)

What it is in plain words: Tariff incidence is the question of who actually pays for a tariff (a tax on imported goods). The politician who imposes the tariff says "the foreign country pays." The reality is usually more complicated: the cost is shared between the foreign exporter (who may lower prices to stay competitive) and the domestic importer or consumer (who pays higher prices).

Why it exists: Tariffs are a policy tool, but their effects are economic. Understanding incidence matters because it determines who is hurt and who benefits. If the foreign exporter absorbs the cost, the tariff is a successful pressure tool. If domestic consumers absorb it, the tariff is a tax on your own people.

A concrete worked example: Canada puts a 50% tariff on US steel. A US steel company sells at \$100 per ton. With the tariff, the Canadian buyer must pay \$150 per ton unless the US company lowers its price. The US company might cut its price to \$80, meaning it earns less but keeps the Canadian customer. The Canadian buyer pays \$120 (\$80 + \$40 tariff). The cost is shared: the US company loses \$20 per ton, the Canadian buyer pays \$20 more, and the Canadian government collects \$40 in tariff revenue.

How it shows up in the news: The Canada-US tariff war is a live example ([CNBC](#)). Canada's 50% tariffs on US steel and aluminum will hit US exporters, but the question is how much they absorb versus pass on.

Rough benchmarks: Studies of the 2018 US-China trade war found that US consumers and importers absorbed nearly all of the tariff cost, meaning the tariffs functioned as a tax on US consumers rather than on China.

Caution: Politicians always claim the other side pays. The empirical evidence usually shows the domestic side pays a large share. When you hear "tariffs on China" or "tariffs on Canada," ask: who actually bears the cost?

Terms from Today's News

- **Brent crude:** The international oil benchmark, priced in London. It's the reference for most oil traded globally, distinct from WTI (West Texas Intermediate), the US benchmark. When you hear "oil hit \$98," it's usually Brent.
- **Reverse merger:** A deal where the smaller company technically acquires the larger one, often for regulatory or branding reasons. The WaFd-EverBank deal is a reverse merger: EverBank is bigger, but WaFd's corporate structure survives ([CNBC](#)).
- **Sovereign AI:** The idea that countries should have their own AI models and infrastructure rather than relying on US or Chinese companies. Mistral's €3 billion raise is a sovereign AI play ([TechCrunch](#)).
- **Multimodal:** An AI model that can process multiple types of input (text, images, audio) together. DeepSeek V4.1 Flash natively integrates multimodal capabilities ([finance.biggo.com](#)).
- **Operation Economic Outcast:** The US program of sanctions against Iran, now extended to all remaining unsanctioned Iranian airlines ([CNBC](#)).
- **Exclusion zone:** A declared area where a country or group says it will prevent entry or transit. Iran is threatening an exclusion zone through the Strait of Hormuz ([Fortune](#)).

10. Bottom Line

The world is getting more expensive in three ways at once. Oil at \$98 threatens to push inflation back up just

as the Fed is considering rate hikes. Canada's tariffs add costs to US consumers. And the AI buildout's power

needs are driving up the cost of electricity infrastructure. All three pressures point the same direction: higher prices, higher rates, and a more difficult environment for debt-funded projects.

What changed since the previous brief: The Middle East war has spread to Saudi Arabia, with the Houthis attacking Saudi energy facilities and Brent crossing \$98. Canada's retaliatory tariffs took effect, escalating the US trade war. Qualcomm got a \$4 billion vote of confidence from Amazon in the AI chip race. Mistral raised €3 billion for sovereign AI. DeepSeek launched a beta of V4.1

Flash. And the nuclear-for-AI buildout accelerated with NextEra's \$1.9 billion loan for the Duane Arnold restart.

The through-line: Every major story today is about who pays. The Houthis attack Saudi oil, and the world pays at the pump. Canada tariffs US goods, and US consumers pay. Amazon backs Qualcomm, and the AI supply chain pays for diversification. The AI buildout needs power, and utilities are the new kings. The question is no longer whether the AI buildout happens, but who controls the inputs: chips, power, and capital. That's where the investment opportunities and the geopolitical leverage both live.

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